Finalist Handbook

UMHackathon 2026

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Welcome Message

Dear Finalists,

Congratulations and welcome to the grand finale of UM Hackathon 2026! Out of many incredible submissions, you've made it to the top. This year's hackathon celebrates innovation, collaboration, and impact, and you've proven yourselves capable of making a real difference.

As you gear up for the final stretch, this booklet will be your go-to guide. Inside, you'll find everything you need to navigate the final phase, from key event details to judging criteria, pitching tips, and available resources. Let's build something amazing together.

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Final Round Structure

The final round is divided into two main sub-phases.

Online Sub-Phase: 29 April 2026 (11:10 PM) – 2 May 2026 (7:59 AM)

During this period, teams will be developing:

- Code Repository
- Refined Quality Assurance Testing Document (PDF)
- Deployment Plan (PDF)
- Business Proposal (PDF)
- Final Round Pitch Deck (PDF)

Physical Sub-Phase: 2 May 2026 (8:00 AM) – 3 May 2026 (8:00 PM)

2nd May 2026:

- Teams must report to FCSIT, UM, for an intensive 24-hour in-person hackathon session. Meals, accommodation on FCSIT (one night), WiFi and on-site mentorship will be provided.
- **Important:** Attendance throughout the entire physical sub-phase is mandatory for all team members unless presented with valid proof. Failure to attend physically or leaving the venue without permission will result in immediate disqualification from UMHackathon 2026.

3rd May 2026:

- 8:00 AM: Participants will be transported to the final round venue (KPS, UM).
- 10:00 AM: Pitching session starts.
- 4:30 PM: Closing Ceremony & Awards Announcement.

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Date	Time	Activity
29th April 2026	11:10 PM	Finalists Announced + Online Sub-Phase Begins
2nd May 2026	8:00 AM	Start of Physical Sub-Phase at FCSIT, UM
	1:30 PM	On-site Mentorship Sessions
3rd May 2026	7:59:59 AM	Final Submission Deadline
	8.00 AM	Participants transported to final round pitching venue (KPS, UM)
	9:00 AM	Breakfast at KPS
	10.00 AM	Final Pitching Sessions Begin
	4:30 PM	Closing Ceremony + Awards Announcement

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Navigation for Final Round

DAY 1 (2nd May 2026): FCSIT UM

- **Arrival & Registration:** Head to the Faculty of Computer Science and Information Technology (FCSIT) **Block B** for registration. Here is the Guide Video.
- **Bags:** After registration, please bring your bags and belongings with you to Dewan Kuliah 1 (DK1) for the participant briefing. After the briefing concludes, you will carry your luggage along with you to your designated hacking room.

DAY 2 (3rd May): KPS Auditorium

- **Venue Transfer:** After the team submits their deliverables, our organizing committee will assist with transferring participants from FCSIT to the Kompleks Perdana Siswa (KPS) Auditorium.
- **Belonging:** Please ensure you bring all your bags and belongings with you during this transfer to KPS.

Need Help? Our team will be stationed along the way with clear signage and directions, so don't worry, you won't get lost! If you're unsure at any point, just approach our committee in UMHackathon T-shirts; they'll be happy to help!

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Crucial Arrival Information

Please note the specific arrival times and locations for both days so you can start your hackathon experience smoothly:

DAY 1 (2nd May 2026)

1. Arrive between **8:00 AM and 9:30 AM** at **FCSIT UM (Faculty of Computer Science and Information Technology)**.
2. Registration at the **Block B foyer of FCSIT**. Click to Explore.
3. Proceed directly to Dewan Kuliah 1 for participant briefing.
4. After Briefing, bring all your belongings to Block A guided by our committee and seat at your designated place. You should keep your items within your supervision.

DAY 2 (3rd May 2026)

1. Participants pack their belongings and ensure the designated areas at FCSIT are cleared immediately after 8:00 AM.
2. Bring along your belongings and proceed to the FCSIT pick-up point. Dedicated vehicles will be stationed here to transport all participants to the KPS Auditorium (Kompleks Perdana Siswa).
3. **Arrive** before **9:00 AM** at the **KPS Auditorium.**

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Event Schedule

Day 1: 2nd May (Location: FCSIT UM)

Time	Activity	Venue
8:00 AM – 9:30 AM	Participant Arrival and Registration at FCSIT UM	Dewan Kuliah 1
9:30 AM – 10:00 AM	Participant Briefing	Dewan Kuliah 1
10:00 AM – 12:45 PM	Hacking Time	Cube Room, Bilik Kuliah 1, Bilik Kuliah 2, Micro Lab 2
12:45 PM – 1:30 PM	Lunch Break / Zuhr Prayer	Block A Open Area, Block B Open Area
1:30 PM – 5:00 PM	Hacking Time Mentorship Sessions	Cube Room, Bilik Kuliah 1 & 2, Micro Lab 2 Logtech Rooms
5:00 PM – 5:30 PM	Asar Prayer / Tea Time	Surau
5:30 PM – 7:00 PM	Hacking Time Mentorship Sessions	Cube Room, Bilik Kuliah 1 & 2, Micro Lab 2 Logtech Rooms
7:00 PM – 8:45 PM	Dinner Break / Maghrib & Isyak Prayer	Block A Open Area, Block B Open Area

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Time	Activity	Venue
8:45 PM – 11:59 PM	Hacking Time	Cube Room, Bilik Kuliah 1 & 2, Micro Lab 2

Day 2: 3rd May (Location: FCSIT to KPS Auditorium)

Time	Activity	Venue
12:00 AM – 8:00 AM	Hacking Time	FCSIT
8:00 AM – 9:00 AM	Participant Arrival at KPS	FCSIT to KPS Auditorium
9:00 AM – 10:00 AM	Breakfast	KPS Auditorium
10:00 AM – 12:40 PM	Live Pitching (Parallel Sessions) / Quarantine *(10 mins pitching, 5 mins Q&A)*	KPS Auditorium Domain 1: DP1 Domain 2: DP2
12:40 PM – 1:30 PM	Lunch Break / Zuhr Prayer / Adjudication / Judge Lunch	Participants: KPS Auditorium
1:30 PM – 4:00 PM	Live Pitching (Parallel Sessions) / Quarantine *(10 mins pitching, 5 mins Q&A)*	KPS Auditorium Domain 1: DP1 Domain 2: DP2

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Time	Activity	Venue
4:00 PM – 4:30 PM	Adjudication & VIP Arrival	KPS Auditorium
4:30 PM – 6:30 PM	Closing & Award Ceremony	KPS Auditorium
6:30 PM – 8:00 PM	Participants' Dinner / VIP Dinner	KPS Auditorium

Few Important Details:

- ✔ After Registration, Kindly collect your T Shirt & Lanyard from the Registration Counter.
- ✔ Participants are provided with Lunch & Dinner (2nd May) and Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner (3rd May). So, on the 2nd of May, there is no breakfast.
- ✔ Participants/Teams who are bringing their own vehicle can park at the “Students Parking” section behind Block A, FCSIT.
- ✔ Participants can enjoy the food anywhere within the venue except their Hacking Rooms.
- ✔ Participants are encouraged to bring water bottles and have water dispensers to refill.

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Rules & Deliverables

Deliverables

- Code Repository
- Refined Quality Assurance Testing Document (in PDF format)
- Deployment Plan (in PDF format)
- Business Proposal (for the Developed Product, in PDF format)
- Final Round Presentation Pitch Deck (in PDF format)

***** You will submit one Link (Github Repo) and Include these Deliverables in the First Section of Your Readme for easier access.**
*** Your all Deliverables documentation (e.g. Pitch Deck) must include Z AI & YTL AI LABS logo. We will share with you the logo.

General Rules

- All work must be done within the final round timeline.
- Plagiarism and reused content from other events will result in disqualification.
- Any public resources used must be cited.

Safety & Conduct

- Participants may not leave the venue unless for emergencies or valid reasons.
- Smoking, alcohol, and sharp tools are prohibited.
- Respect the venue - no littering or inappropriate behavior.
- First-aid support is available at the counter throughout the event.

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Mentorship & Guidance

Session Schedule & Structure

- **Final Round (Online):** 30 April 2026 – 1 May 2026
- **Final Round (Physical):** 2 May 2026
- **Duration:** Each mentorship session is strictly **20 minutes** per team.
- **Punctuality:** Teams must join their scheduled sessions on time. Late arrivals will result in lost time, as each team must leave promptly after their 20-minute slot to make space for the next team.

Booking Your Slots

- **Online Sessions (30 Apr – 1 May):** The mentorship arrangement will be done via **mentor-specific Google Forms**. Links for the different mentors and booking instructions will be provided to help you secure your slots.
- **Physical Sessions (2 May):** Booking for the physical mentorship slots will be managed via a **Google Sheet** (further instructions and the link will be provided closer to the event).

How to Use Your Mentorship Time: Mentors will be present to evaluate your progress and help refine your minimum viable products (MVPs) into actual implementations. Use your 20-minute sessions to:

- Seek guidance on technical and ideation aspects, including artificial intelligence, software development, and overall problem-solving.
- Ask specific questions regarding programming, frameworks, and relevant technologies.
- Refine your solutions to ensure they stay focused on the competition's objectives and align with the judging criteria.
- Use your mentor as a sounding board to brainstorm ideas, overcome bottlenecks, and improve your product's clarity, innovation, and feasibility.

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Judging & Evaluations

Each team must prepare the following and submit them through the official portal (umhackathon.com) before the deadline:

Deliverables:

- Code Repository
- Refined Quality Assurance Testing Document (PDF format)
- Deployment Plan (PDF format)
- Business Proposal (for the Developed Product, PDF format)
- Final Round Presentation Pitch Deck (PDF format)

Pitching Format:

- **10 minutes** to present your solution
- **5 minutes** for Q&A by the judging panel

Time will be strictly enforced. Exceeding the time limit during the pitching session will result in a deduction of marks.

Presentation Tips:

- **Demonstrate:** Include a live demonstration or walkthrough of your working prototype/MVP.
- **Emphasize Value:** Highlight the impact, technical innovation, and real-world feasibility of your solution.
- **Teamwork:** Show a clear division of team responsibilities.
- **Rehearse:** Practice your flow to ensure you fit comfortably within the 10-minute timeframe!

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Judging Criteria

Projects will be assessed based on a holistic review of technical innovation, clarity of execution, usability, and communication effectiveness. All judging panel decisions are final, and no individual requests for score reviews will be entertained. The organizing committee reserves the right to amend the judging criteria at the discretion of the panel.

Breakdown of each category:

- **Business Proposal & Market Potential (20%):** Realistic market planning and strategy, competitor and value proposition analysis, business model canvas, and financial projections.
- **Deployment Plan & Production Architecture (20%):** Justified technical stack and scalability, CI/CD pipeline and automation, secure integration and credential management.
- **Quality Assurance & Reliability Execution (15%):** Evident test execution and automation, defect traceability and risk follow-through, reasoned transparency and architecture trade-offs.
- **Production Engineering and Code Maturity (15%):** Production-ready code, efficient token and cost management, and good security and repository hygiene.
- **Fit, Validation, Feasibility (15%):** Clear and tangible problem-solution fit with value realization, evident market and technical validation, and real-world feasibility.
- **Final Pitch and Technical Defense (15%):** Clarity, storytelling, confidence, visual appeal, and smooth presentation.

Pro Tips for Teams:

- Ensure your GitHub is organized with proper folder structure and updated commits.
- Keep your deliverables focused (better to show 3 working features than 5 broken ones).
- Use visuals in slides (charts, workflow diagrams) to convey your story effectively.

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Code of Conduct

All participants are expected to adhere to the highest standards of integrity, professionalism, and collaboration. The following examples of conduct are mandatory:

- **Access:** Only participants with official name tags may access the event venue.
- **Respect:** Show respect to mentors, judges, volunteers, other teams, the organizing committee, and university staff.
- **Punctuality:** Be punctual for all activities, including mentoring sessions and pitching.
- **Originality:** Ensure all submitted work is original, created during the hackathon, and properly cited.
- **Integrity:** Use only permitted tools; do not engage in plagiarism or code theft.
- **Behavior:** Refrain from any form of harassment, bullying, discrimination, or offensive language.
- **Prohibited Items:** Do not smoke, vape, drink alcohol, or bring any harmful objects to the venue.
- **Cleanliness:** Keep all work areas clean and return any borrowed items or materials.
- **Network Usage:** Use the provided WiFi responsibly, no torrenting, illegal downloads, or hacking.
- **Safety:** Follow all safety instructions and ask for help immediately in case of an emergency.
- **Dress Code:** Dress appropriately; formal wear is compulsory for final pitching presentations.
- **Compliance:** Comply with any additional instructions given by the organizing committee.

Violation of any of these rules may result in disqualification, removal from the event, or further action based on severity.

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Frequently Asked Questions

1. **Is it compulsory to involve all team members in the final pitching presentation?**

   No, it is not obligatory to include all team members in the final pitching presentation. However, delivering a dynamic, clear, concise, and convincing presentation is essential for achieving high scores in the judging criteria, particularly in the preliminary round.

2. **What should be submitted by each team?**

   Participants for the final round are required to produce a working prototype (Minimum Viable Product) and submit their Code Repository, Refined Quality Assurance Testing Document (PDF), Deployment Plan (PDF), Business Proposal (PDF), and Final Round Presentation Pitch Deck (PDF). All materials must be submitted through the submission tab on the official UMHackathon 2026 website.

3. **Is it mandatory for participants to stay at the venue the whole time?**

   All participants must stay at the venue throughout the event for safety purposes. You may only leave for emergencies or with explicit approval from the organizers.

4. **Is food provided throughout the physical dates of the final round?**

   Yes, we will provide a buffet for all participants throughout the physical dates of the final round of UMHackathon 2026. Vegetarian meals are available upon request as stated in the registration form. There are also accessible food and drinks machines nearby.

5. **Will accommodation be provided throughout the event?**

   Yes, accommodation will be provided. All participants will stay at the assigned places in

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FCSIT (Faculty of Computer Science and Information Technology), Universiti Malaya. However, participants are highly recommended to bring their **extensions, sleeping bags, sleeping items, personal items, and other items** deemed needed by participants, as those are not provided by the organizing committee of UMHackathon 2026. All participants are highly recommended to always keep their belongings under their supervision. The organizer is not liable for lost or damaged items.

6. **What should I wear during the final round?**

   Casual is suitable for the hackathon period. Formal attire is compulsory for the final pitching session on 3rd May.

7. **Can we reuse old code or pre-developed content?**

   Participants are recommended to build upon and modify the code submitted during the preliminary round for the final round. However, the use of any pre-developed code from other hackathons, competitions, or prior projects is strictly prohibited.

8. **Is there a WiFi connection available at the event location?**

   Yes, a WiFi connection will be available during the hackathon to ensure that all the participants can work. However, it's recommended for participants to have their own data plan in case of emergencies.

9. **Will transportation be provided throughout the event?**

   No, transportation will not be provided; all participants must cover their travel expenses to the venue. However, we will arrange transportation on 3rd May 2026 from 8:00 am to 9:00 am after the final submission. Transportation arrangements during the hackathon will be allocated based on team size. Teams with up to 3 members will be provided with 1 vehicle, while larger teams (4–5 members) may be assigned 2 vehicles, depending on availability.

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10. What if someone gets sick or has an emergency?

First-aid assistance is available on-site. Please alert the organizing committee immediately if a teammate is unwell or injured.

11. Can we observe other teams' presentations during the pitching session?

Participants must remain in the waiting room before and after their pitching session. Presentations are private between teams and domain judges. So, participants are not allowed to observe the other team's performance or presentation.

12. Will certificates be provided to participants for their participation in the hackathon?

E-certificates will be emailed to the team leader for teams that successfully submit the deliverables. Also, participants will be provided with UMHackathon T-shirts.

13. Who should we contact for further queries?

For enquiries, kindly reach out to us via email at umhackathon@um.edu.my or through the Discord Server.

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Thank You & Final Words

We're beyond excited to see your final creations. Remember: it's not just about winning, it's about learning, growing, and pushing your limits. A big shoutout to our sponsors, partners, mentors, and judges who made this possible.

Whether you walk away with a prize or not, you've already accomplished something big. So, give it your all and have fun!

See you at the finals!

Warm Regards,
UMHackathon 2026 Organising Committee

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